WARSHIP BATTLES 1939–45

THE GERMAN NAVY was not capable of a fleet battle with the British Royal Navy in World War II. Germany possessed only a handful of large warships, no carriers, and an inadequate number of destroyers. But the best German ships were modern, fast, and heavily armed for their size. Despite the loss of *Graf Spee* at the River Plate in December 1939, commerce raiding by German warships such as *Scharnhorst* and *Gneisenau* was frighteningly effective in the first 18 months of the war. The hunting down and sinking of the battleship *Bismarck* in May 1941 was a turning point. Although substantial Royal Navy forces were tied down by the need to neutralize the threat posed by the presence of warships such as *Scharnhorst* and *Tirpitz* in the Norwegian fjords, Hitler lost all faith in his surface ships. Admiral Erich Raeder, who had masterminded the creation of the German fleet, was replaced as commander-in-chief by U-boat advocate Admiral Karl Dönitz in January 1943. From then onward the German warships were the hunted rather than the hunters. The mighty *Tirpitz* was eventually sunk without ever having fired its guns against an enemy ship.

THE BATTLE OF THE RIVER PLATE



BATTLE OF THE RIVER PLATE

Date	December 13, 1939
Location	South Atlantic off Uruguay and Argentina
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	GERMANY

COMMANDERS

Henry Harwood	Hans Langsdorff

FORCES

Ships: 1 heavy cruiser, 2 light cruisers	**Ships:** 1 pocket battleship

LOSSES

Men: 100 casualties	**Men:** 96 casualties **Ships:** 1 pocket battleship later scuttled

In the early months of World War II, the Deutschland-class pocket battleship *Admiral Graf Spee* was engaged in commerce raiding in the Indian Ocean and the South Atlantic. Under the command of Captain Hans Langsdorff, the German warship sank nine merchant ships, while chivalrously ensuring that there was no loss of life.

At around 6:15 a.m. on the morning of December 13, 1939, a lookout on *Graf Spee* sighted a cruiser and, it was initially believed, two destroyers. The ships were in fact the Royal Navy's Force G, consisting of the heavy cruiser *Exeter* and the light cruisers *Ajax* and *Achilles*, the latter belonging to the New Zealand Division. Led by Commodore Henry Harwood on board *Ajax*, the cruiser squadron had been hunting for the German commerce raider and correctly guessed it might be lurking off the estuary of the River Plate between Argentina and Uruguay. The Royal Navy ships were outgunned by *Graf Spee*: the pocket battleship had 11-in main guns, compared with *Exeter*'s 8-in and the 6-in armament of the two light cruisers. In the true tradition of the Royal Navy, however, Harwood unhesitatingly attacked. He split his force, with *Exeter* steaming to the south of *Graf Spee* and the cruisers *Ajax* and *Achilles* maneuvering to the north.



Glory of the Navy
The sinking of the *Graf Spee* was a huge boost for British morale. This commemorative magazine celebrates "How we beat the *Graf Spee*."

Fire opened within minutes as the range closed, *Graf Spee* initially focusing upon *Exeter* as the greater threat. The heavy cruiser was soon in trouble. Its bridge was swept by shrapnel, leaving the ship's captain, F. S. Bell, as one of the few survivors. Guns were put out of action, communications destroyed, and fires started. *Ajax* and *Achilles* forced Langsdorff to divide his fire, depending on their speed to survive as salvoes fell around them. By around 7:40 a.m. *Exeter* could no longer fight and limped away from the battle. But without knowing it, *Exeter*'s gunners had succeeded in scoring a crucial hit on *Graf Spee*, destroying her fuel processing system. Langsdorff knew he could not long remain at sea without repairs and headed west for the River Plate. Damaged and short of

